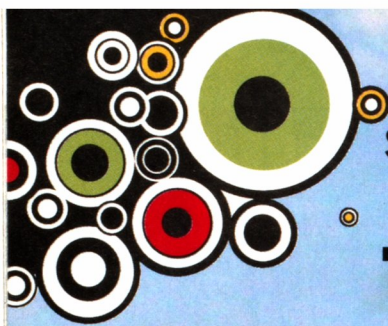




Spirit of **INDIA** Youth Special

The Young **SURGE**

Youngistan lives in India's villages, where aspirations are greater than access to modernity. Yet, as 40 young achievers from across the country show, hopes do translate into hoped-for careers.

By Kaveree Bamzai

521 million of the population is between 12 and 35, with **268 million** men and **253** women

31.1% live in urban India— **12.5%** live in big towns and **18.6%** in small towns—while **68.9%** live in villages

53.4% of those between **12** and **35** are married. **63%** of young women are married compared to **45%** of men

Those looking for a reflection of India's youth in the gleaming glassfronts of its malls and the dazzling multitude of its multiplexes, be warned. The real Youngistan lies elsewhere, away from the Prados and pub-hops, the Gucci shoes and the GMAT tests, in the no-name villages with bad roads and worse sanitation where 68.9 per cent of youngsters between 12 and 35 live. With another 18.6 per cent living in small towns, it is clear that big city youth may have the mojo, but they don't necessarily have the majority.

For ageing leaders, who have suddenly discovered the joys of blogs and Facebook, of Flickr and Twitter, this may come as a rude shock as they try to woo young voters with the ostensible tools of the young. But 97 per cent of young India does not have access to the

Internet and 41 per cent never watch television. What's more, the urban young population, which has benefited the most from liberalisation's often chaotic choices, has fallen by 4.1 per cent in large and small towns since 2005, signifying the gradual ageing of urban India. The visible youth are a minority, with just 3.4 per cent of urban youth between 12 and 35 being skilled workers and 0.3 per cent businessmen/industrialists. In the villages, where the silent majority lives, the professions are largely dictated by the accident of birth or coincidence of circumstances. About 9 per cent are landowners, 7.8 per cent are farm labourers and 7.4 per cent are in jobs other than agriculture, while 25 per cent are studying. Yes, 44.2 per cent contribute to a money-generating activity, but they are caught in a heartbreaking cycle of poverty, says Suresh Nimbalkar, vice-president of Hansa Research, who compiled the data based on IRS 2008 Round 2.

